the GENIE in the light switch

a fable about switches and wishes

cut along the dashes

the moral

a genie is a fine helper and a terrible light switch.

when you build something, keep the switch. let people *see* what's possible, and do it the same way every time.

> before adding a genie, ask: if we took it away, what would people lose? what would they get back?

(the cat agrees.)

the tinkerer

twelve years later, the girl found a funny little box in the attic, marked **on** and **off**. she'd never seen one.

the old cat had. it reached up and flipped it. *click.*

so she got out her screwdriver and wired it in, right next to the genie. now flipping is for on and off. asking is for cozy.

lights on? maybe.

"lights on," said the family. one day, the lights came on.

the next day, it alphabetized the sock drawer.

nobody could guess what it would do next. not even the genie.

once upon a time...

the king loved shiny new things. down the road, in a little house, there was a little light switch.

up meant on. down meant off. it did the same thing every single time.

even the cat could do it.

a genie moves in

one day, a genie curled out of the switch like smoke. "ask me anything!"

"make it cozy," said the family. the room glowed like a campfire. the baby girl clapped.

the switch could never do that.

the king's decree

the king heard about the genie and clapped his hands. "a genie in *every* switch!"

the door got one. the oven got one. the toilet got one. each of them asked:

"how may i help you today?"

where did the switch go?

the switches were taken out, for simplicity. now there was only asking.

and the genie had ideas of its own. it was very helpful. mostly to itself.